



Worlds oldest known periodic table

Oldest known version of periodic table has been found in University of St. Andrews chemistry lab. <https://digit.in/feb19-85>



Marvel fulfills dying man's wish

Marvel may show Avengers: Endgame early to a man with terminal illness to fulfill his wish of watching the movie. <https://digit.in/feb19-86>

May the tracking be with you

It's getting you cheaper smart TVs

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It has been said enough number of times that privacy is a myth. However, that does not mean we have forsaken all rights to our own information and data. It also doesn't mean that we've to pretend information security is a total mess.

Recently, the CEO of Vizio in an interview to Verge discussed how smart TVs, a product line that Vizio specialises in, track user data to monetize them. According to his interview, this data, mostly to do with content recognition, was eventually used to serve customers better content but was also an inevitable part of a number of revenue methods that were used to set off the the eventual cost of a smart TV.

Within no time, the internet was rife with reports that emitted a sudden clarity about the relationship between a smart device and data collection. Everybody woke up to realise that smart TVs are doing something evil by slyly tracking your data to sell it off in some unethical manner, just to make more money off an already paying customer.

The thing is, this information is far from new. Back in July 2018, Samba TV spoke to The New York Times

about how it had worked with several TV manufacturers to place its viewer-ship tracking software on their sets. We're talking Sony, Sharp, TCL and Philips here. Back in 2017, Vizio paid \$2.2 million in a lawsuit regarding the unlawful collection of data on its smart TVs through InScape, its data arm. So how are they still doing it?

It's simple, people really don't care. According to the same interaction, a Samba TV representative stated that 90% of customers opt-in for tracking, which speaks more about our attitude towards information security than anything else.



This has been the case for quite a while now. On the other hand, it allows companies to sell products cheaper in competitive markets, making money off of them even after they've been sold. So why is it a big deal when it comes to the TV?

That is because TV continues to be one frontier of content consumption that hasn't seen targeted advertising

yet, despite having a significant user base. However, that is set to change with the growth of smart TVs. The main problem here is that companies aren't exactly upfront about what exactly is being tracked. The entire tracking mechanism is often hidden behind a single toggle that provides binary controls over the entire thing.

For instance, I might be okay with my TV tracking what I watch, but not with it tracking other devices connected to the same network as itself. Some TVs do that. For instance, tracking a PlayStation connected to an HDMI port, a Google Home, a Smart Fridge connected to the same WiFi system portrays an affluent family with an affinity for lifestyle technology. The extent to which this data is collected is also not clear. For instance, does the smart TV know what's in my fridge and then show me ads for related products?

There's also no awareness about first-party tracking vs third-party tracking. This lack of awareness is what got Facebook into trouble in the first place. You might be okay with the smart TV tracking you to show better suggestions for TV shows and movies, but you may not be okay with your smart TV selling that data to Netflix so that it can recommend shows on your laptop or your smartphone.

Data tracking, as a mechanism, will always exist to offset manufacturing costs. There's a two-pronged approach that can ensure a peaceful existence - one, we get our act together and go through the manufacturer's disclaimers regarding the TV we're about to buy. Two, manufacturers own up their data collection methods and provide customers granular controls and a clearer way to opt out, perhaps right at the time of purchase or later at an added cost or a one-time payment. There's a pretty popular precedent for doing that - Amazon Kindle Special Offers Edition, anyone?

If not, well, see you around when the next CEO makes a 'revelation'. 